The great bone rush of 1877 · for 2 to 4 diggers · 20-30 minutes

DIGGERS

Rival excavations in three field seasons

You are rival paleontologists working the same badlands. Between every pair of neighboring camps lies a **dig site**, and a site belongs to whoever brought up the finest find there last. Over three field seasons, earn the most **prestige** from the sites you hold.

Components

- **54 fossil cards:** numbers 1 to 9, six of each. Each copy of a number comes from a different dinosaur, and a species' nine cards lay out in three rows of three as one fossil slab. Species is only art; it never affects play.
- **4 field guides** (reference cards)
- **4 dig-site markers** (thin strips)

Setup

Diggers	Deck	Hand	Sites
2	remove 8s and 9s (42 cards)	12	3, all between you
3	all 54 cards	11	1 between each pair of neighbors
4	all 54 cards	10	1 between each pair of neighbors

Place the markers, shuffle, and deal each digger a hand.



Circles are camps, bars are dig-site markers. With three or four diggers, you may only use the two sites beside your camp.

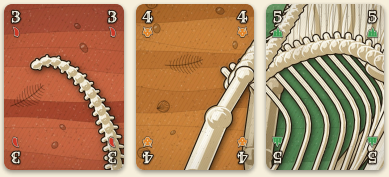
Your hand is locked. Pick up your cards one at a time, each to the right of the last, and **never rearrange them**. Hold them so the numbers face you. The order only changes when cards leave your hand or when you insert a new one.

Choose a first digger. Play goes to the left.

Finds

A **find** is one or more cards that sit **next to each other** in your hand and form one of:

- **A lone bone:** any single card.
- **A spine:** consecutive numbers in order, up or down, such as 3-4-5 or 7-6-5.
- **A bone bed:** all the same number, such as 8-8-8.



A spine 3-4-5. The species don't matter.

Each season limits how many cards a find may have: **3**, then **4**, then **5** (see Seasons).

Which find is better: more cards beats fewer. With the same count, a bone bed beats a spine. Still tied, the higher total wins. An exact tie does not beat.



A bone bed of two 7s beats any two-card spine, but loses to any three-card find.

Your turn

Do **one** of these:

Excavate

Lay a find from your hand at a dig site **beside your camp** (with two diggers, any of the three). If the site is empty, any find will do. If a find is already there, yours or a rival's, yours must **beat** it; the old find is discarded. Slide your find to your side of the marker: you hold that site.

Poach

Take **one card from either end** of a find at a site beside your camp and insert it **anywhere** in your hand. If that empties the site, nobody holds it.

Then **send a specimen:** give any one card from your hand, even the one you just took, to the digger across that site. They either insert it anywhere in their hand, or turn it away; a turned-away card is discarded for the season.

> Poaching the end of a rival's find weakens it; poaching your own lets you rebuild your hand. Either way, you hand a card across.

If you can do neither, pass.

Example

Ada's hand reads 2 · 5 · 6 · 7 · 9. A rival holds the site between them with a spine 3-4. Ada can excavate 5-6-7 there: three cards beat two. Or she could poach the 4 from that spine, insert it between her 2 and 5, and send her 9 across.

Seasons

A game is three seasons. Each is worth more and allows bigger finds:

Season	Each site is worth	Finds up to
1	1 prestige	3 cards
2	2 prestige	4 cards
3	4 prestige	5 cards

Ending a season

The moment any digger's hand is **empty**, the season ends. Nobody takes another turn. Each digger scores every site they hold, at that season's value.

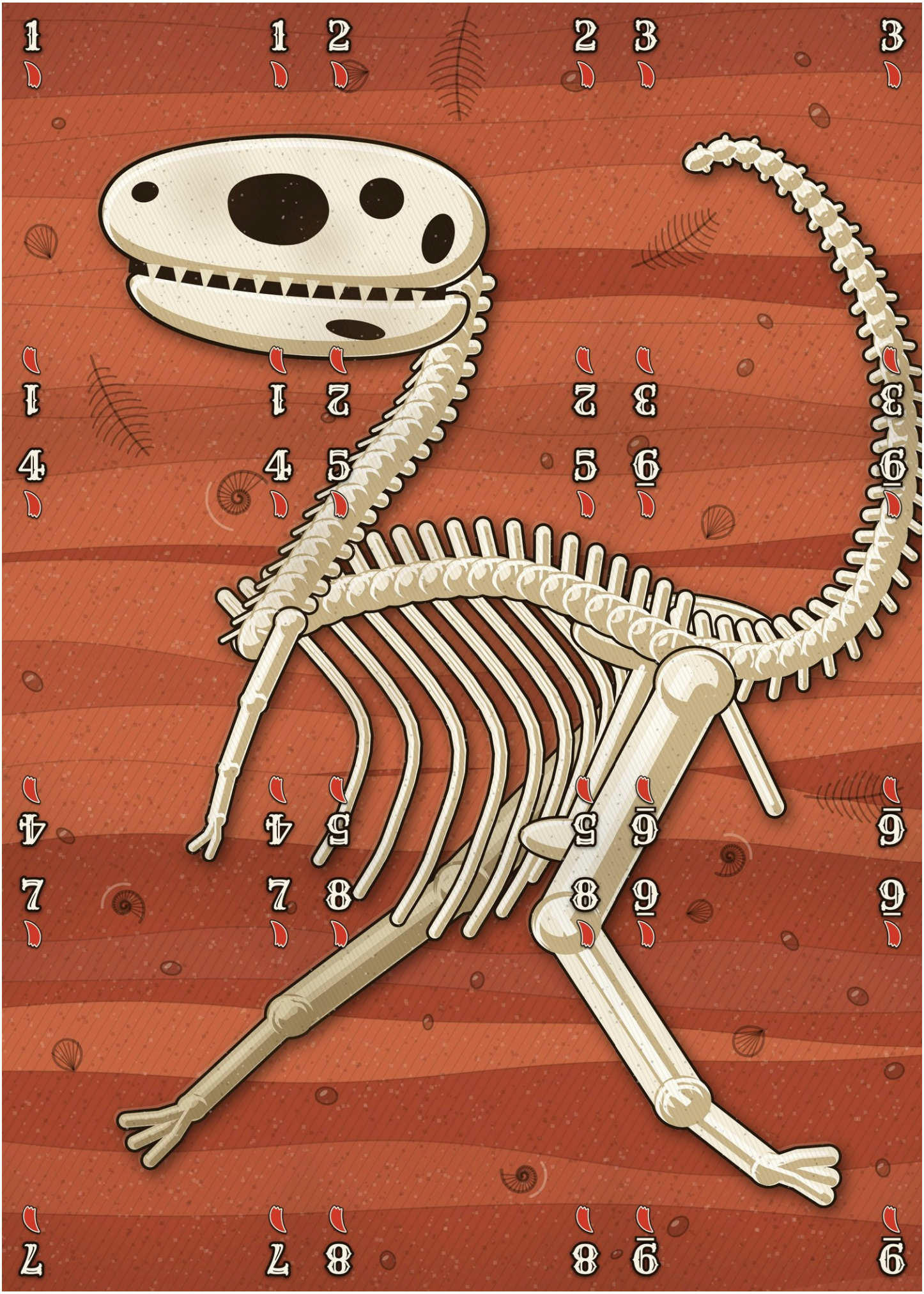
Then clear every site, gather all the cards, shuffle, and deal fresh hands. Nothing carries over. The next digger to the left goes first.

Winning

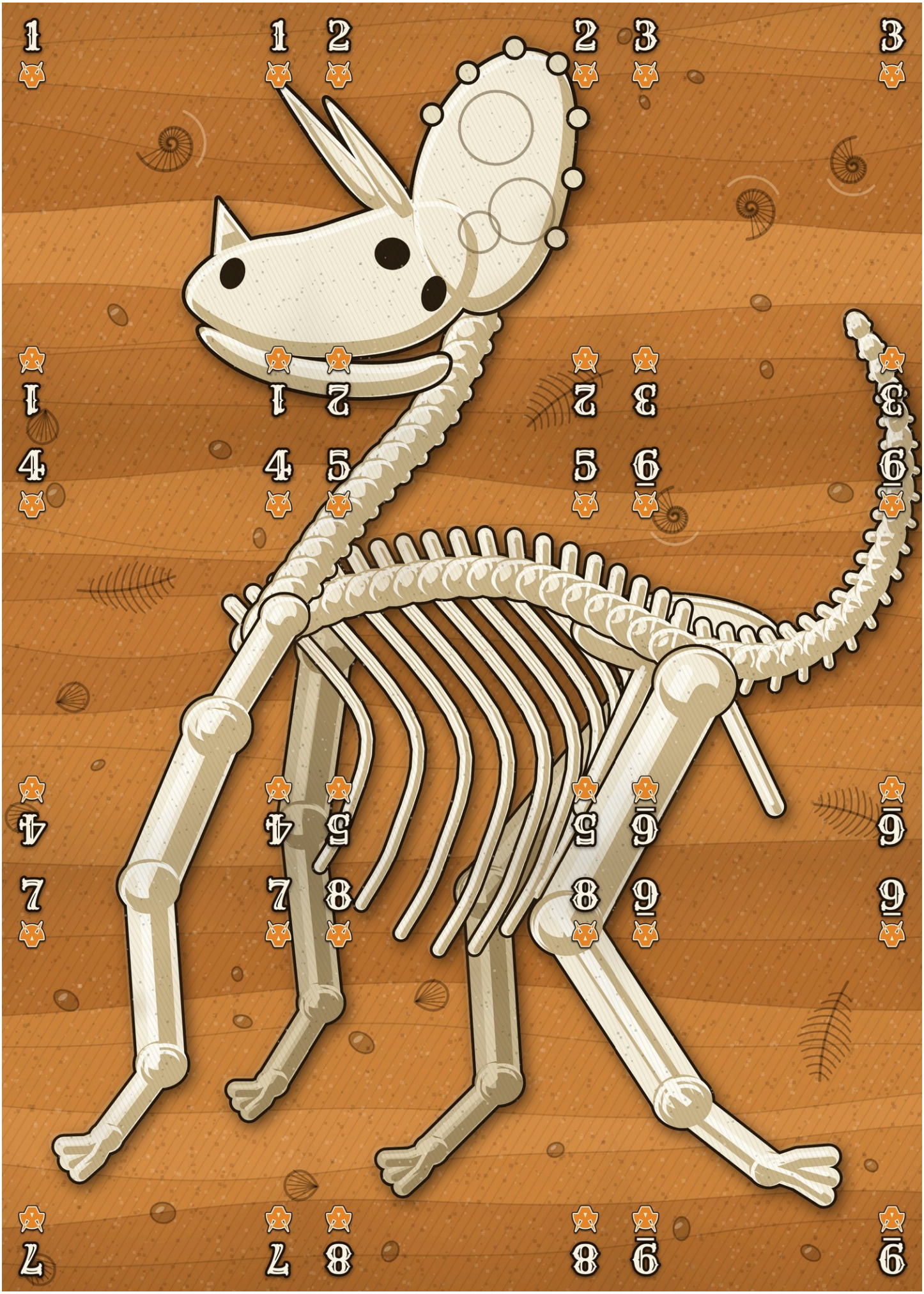
After the third season, the most prestige wins. If tied, the digger who ended the most seasons by emptying their hand wins; if still tied, the most prestige in the third season.

Tips from the field

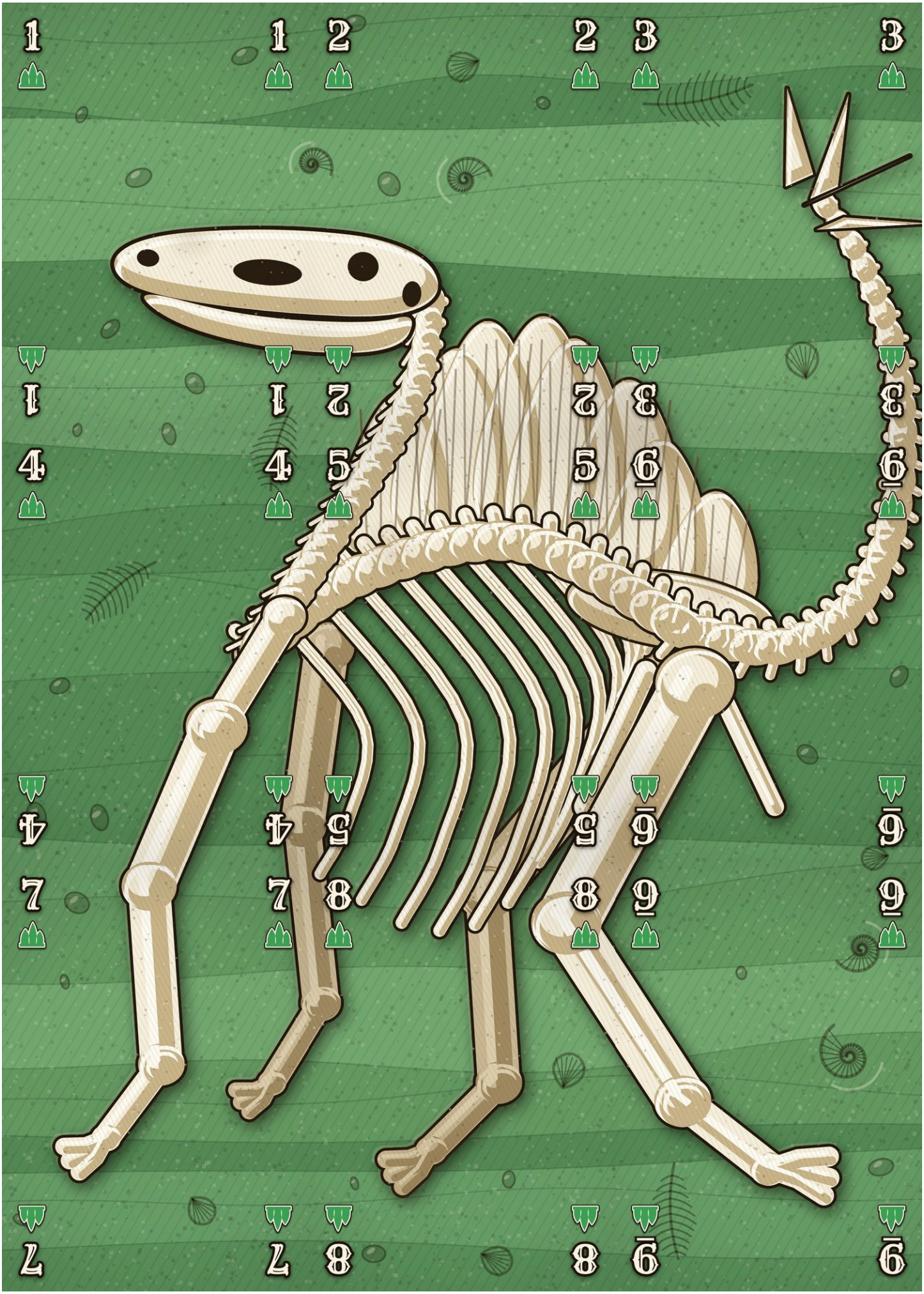
- Every card you play makes your hand shorter. Ending the season while you hold the most sites is the cleanest win.
- A big find is safe only until someone brings a bigger one. Watch how many cards your neighbors have left.
- The specimen you send can be a gift or a weight. A lone 1 between two 7s helps nobody.
- Season three is worth as much as the first two together. Nobody is out of it.



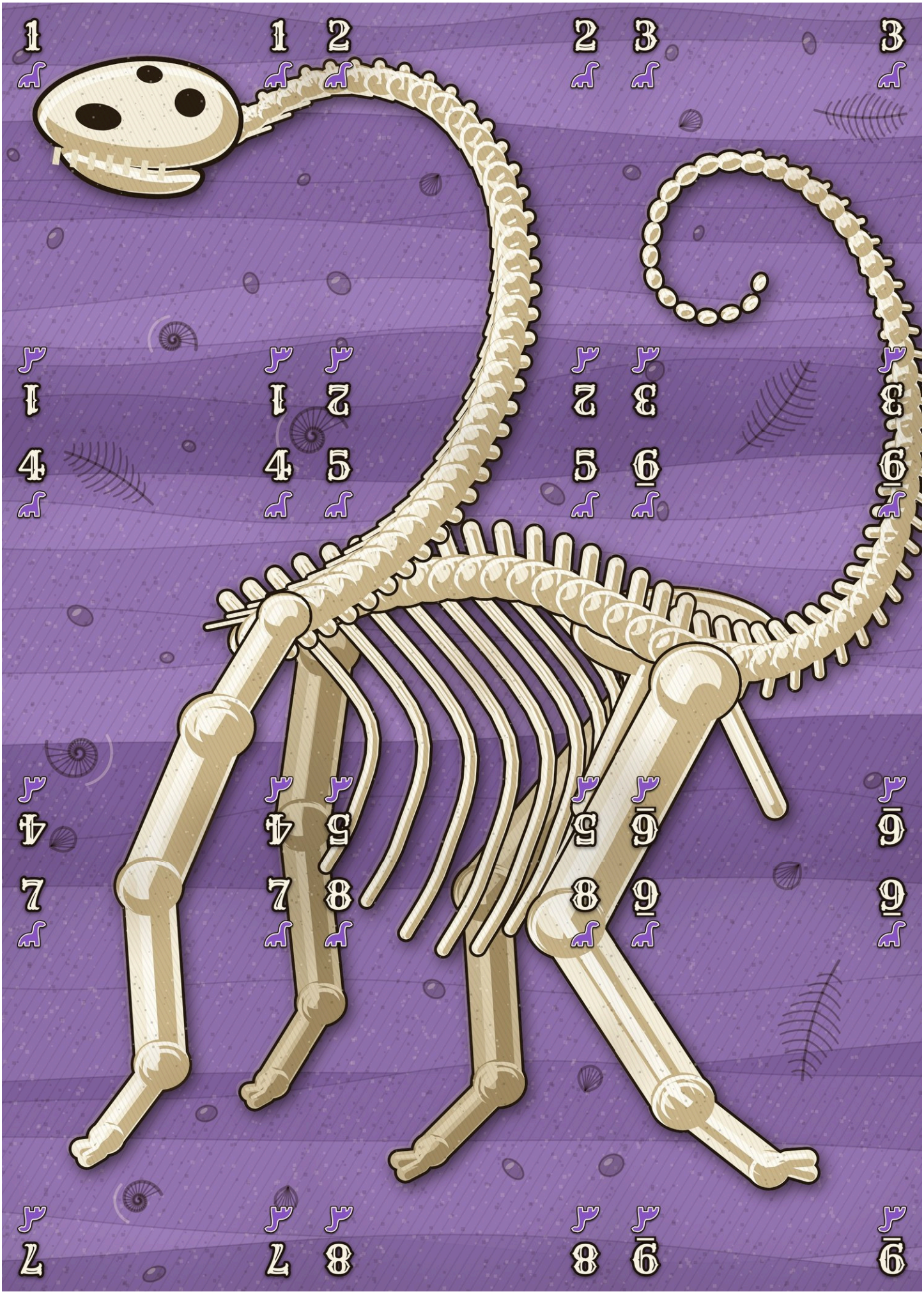
Tyrannosaurus · red sandstone · cards 1-9, laid out as they sit in the slab



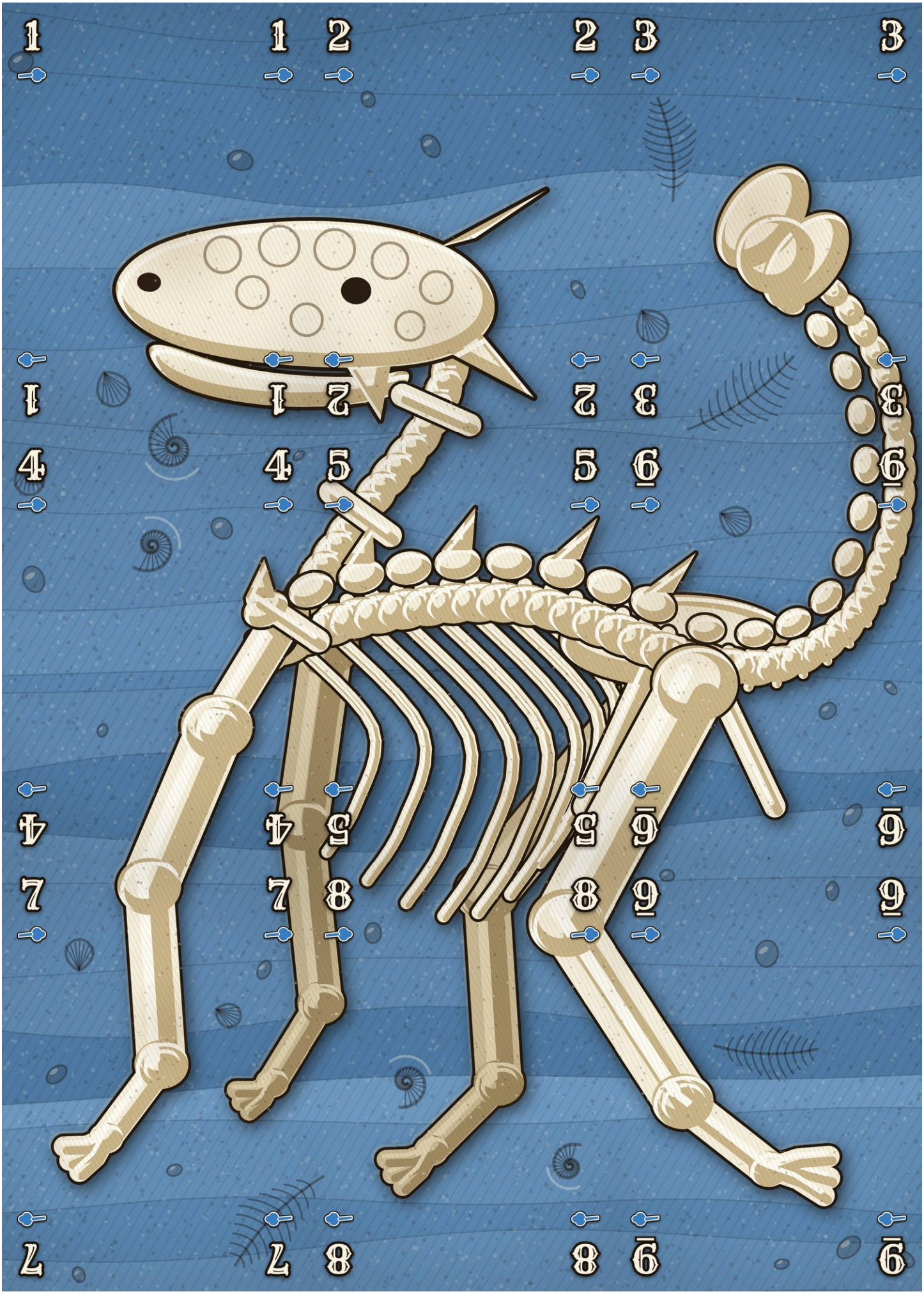
Triceratops · orange ironstone · cards 1-9, laid out as they sit in the slab



Stegosaurus · green mudstone · cards 1–9, laid out as they sit in the slab



Brontosaurus · purple shale · cards 1–9, laid out as they sit in the slab



Ankylosaurus · blue slate · cards 1–9, laid out as they sit in the slab

Parasaurolophus · golden limestone · cards 1-9, laid out as they sit in the slab

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What's Good Board Games

Card backs (optional): print on the reverse of any sheet, or sleeve the cards over plain backs

Field Guide

On your turn, do one

Excavate

Play 1 or more **adjacent** cards from your hand to a site beside you: a **spine** (3-4-5) or a **bone bed** (all one number). To take a claimed site, beat its find: more cards, then bed over spine, then higher total.

Poach

Take an **end** card from a find beside you into your hand, then offer any card to the rival across that site. Kept, or out for the season.

Season	Site worth	Finds up to
1	1 prestige	3 cards
2	2 prestige	4 cards
3	4 prestige	5 cards

Winning

Most prestige after three seasons. Tie: most seasons you ended by emptying your hand, then most prestige in season 3.

A season ends the moment any hand is empty.
Never rearrange your hand.

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Four field guides and four dig-site markers. Mount the markers on card stock for weight.